

2. 'Regardless of the era and geographical location, piracy is always driven by economics.' Do you agree? Why or why not? (Use two examples to support your answer)

Piracy is always rooted in economic logic, but economics alone does not explain its emergence. Piracy flourishes when economic deprivation intersects with political weakness and geographic opportunity. This pattern holds across eras and regions. Two case studies separated by two centuries, on opposite ends of the globe illustrate this with striking consistency: the confederacy of Cheng I Sao in the early nineteenth-century South China, and the rise of Somali piracy following the collapse of the Somali state in 1991.

Cheng I Sao and the Red Flag Fleet (1775 - 1844)

In the early nineteenth century, piracy was a direct response to a failing agrarian economy. Cheng I Sao was born into the Tanaka people of southern China. Being forced to work in a floating brothel on a flower boat in Guangdong, conditions were cramped and abusive. As such poverty was rampant and maritime raiding was a strategy for survival.

The Qing dynasty's inability to manage its population led to a surplus of landless people and impoverished fishers. Economics drove these individuals to sea, but it was the political weakness of the Qing navy and geographic complexity of the Guangdong coastline that allowed Cheng I Sao to consolidate her massive confederacy of the Red Flag Fleet. Her fleets controlled trade routes and coastal regions, establishing alternative forms of authority that competed with imperial authority. Thus, the weakness of the Qing dynasty and the ability of Cheng I Sao to provide a better form of structure and protection to the people was one of the key drivers to sustaining piracy beyond its initial economic drivers.

Somali Piracy and the collapse of the state (1991 - present)

When Somalia gained independence in 1960, the colonial powers left behind administrative borders that cut across clan territories. Clan loyalties consistently overrode national ones, and a revolving door of authoritarian regimes kept Somalia on the edge of collapse. When the Barre regime fell in 1991, it took with it the only institution capable of controlling the Somalia waters. Open exploitation of Somalia followed, where foreign fishing fleets from Japan, Korea and parts of Europe moved into Somali waters illegally and fished on an industrial scale. This destroyed seabeds and caused fish stocks that coastal communities depended on to plunge. Foreign vessels also used Somali waters as a dumping ground for waste, with no functional state left to stop them. Thus, locals found their livelihoods destroyed. Push factors of poverty and political collapse then pushed Somalians to turn to piracy.

However, over time, piracy in Somalia shifted from a means of survival to something more deliberate and profitable. By the 2000s, a single successful raid on a commercial vessel in the

Gulf of Aden could net a crew up to \$75,000. This was far more than what most Somalians would earn in a lifetime of legitimate work of around \$35,000. At this point, piracy was no longer driven by poverty but rather by an extraordinary return on investment that a collapsed state and a strategically located coastline made possible. As the Gulf of Aden is one of the world's busiest shipping lanes, running directly past a stretch of coastline with no government, raiding there was lucrative. Thus, not piracy in Somalia in the 21st century is not simply the profile of impoverished fisher folk but rather all the hallmarks of organized crime.

5. Read the primary documents accompanying the Wadsworth chapter on ‘Dwarf Bandits’ in Global Piracy. Select two documents and discuss what they reveal about the wokou.

In his 1535 accounts, Ming magistrate Hsueh Ying-ch’I exposes the wokou phenomenon as a crisis of domestic subversion rather than mere foreign aggression by Japanese.

Hsueh identifies the label “Wo” as a deliberate pirate strategy rather than just a derogatory term used by the state. Chinese rebels intentionally adopted this identity as a “trick” to “hide themselves” and externalise blame. By framing their raids as foreign incursions, they caused the state to categorize their piracy as external threats rather than internal traitors. This allowed them to secure a clean identity, thus effectively bypassing the Ming’s maritime bans without being branded as traitors or subjecting their families to state retribution.

Hsueh also asserts that the Chinese were the strategic architects of the wokou raids, while the Japanese served merely as operational support. The Chinese in the wokou were classified as “Ringleaders” who “invited the WO barbarians to be their helpers”. This reveals the wokou as a sophisticated, hybrid network where local intelligence by Chinese and operational support by Japanese provided expertise to pirate efficiently.

This source also shows us that the wokou are a symptom of failed governance. “Being rebels of their Middle kingdom”, the locals found it more viable to align with the Japanese than to follow imperial law. Furthermore, the fact that the pirates could penetrate “deep into the land” and return with “loads of gold” highlights how the state failed to maintain order and uphold maritime authority.

In the Memoirs of Sato Shinen no Shuki, we get to see insider information about the Wokou operations, thus revealing more about them.

This source reveals the wokou as an economic enterprise. The Wokou’s were primarily driven by profit as motivation for their piracy. They viewed piracy as a way to “become wealthy” and “enrich their families”. They rapidly expanded their organisation to “over a thousand men” and increased their military strength in order to strategically plan their attacks against foreign armies to “gain profits”. Thus, calculated investments in expanding their crew and military capabilities shows us that the wokou were strategic and profit driven in their endeavours.

This source highlights that the wokou were adept in adopting western technology early. They adopted the use of guns in 1554 to counter the large armies of the Ming. This technological shift “increased their military strength”, thus allowing them to challenge established state defenses and successfully attack fortified areas like Ping-hai.

The source tells us the Wokou comprised individuals of diverse nationalities and socio-economic statuses. With what started out as Japanese pirates from the provinces of Iyo and Bingo, by 1563,

the wokou had grown to “1532 men” where “two or three hundred” of them were Chinese. The crews were also not limited to warriors and instead included “ronins, fishermen, scoundrels” and “others from the Kyushu-Shikoku area”. This shows the wokou were a mix of various social classes and nationalities.

Poster: imagine we are holding a showcase/display in the foyer of the Central library. Your poster will be enlarged and on display. This is not a 'call to action' but a chance to engage the public/students to learn more about the topic. Posters can include images and text. Try to find a balance. Briefly elaborate on your poster in no more than 100-150 words. Include some discussion of the sources you drew on or which inspired this poster.

Popular culture has long romanticised the supernatural. Vampires, ghosts and witches dominate films and novels. Notably, pirates occupy this same fantasy space, immortalised through shows such as "one piece". Yet, unlike their fictional counterparts, piracy remains a real and active threat on the world's oceans today. This poster thus aims to bridge fantasy and reality. The final panel features a real photograph of a Somali pirate and a vessel. This aims to rupture the fictional tone and ground the focus of the poster back to present day reality. Data from the ICC International Maritime Bureau's live piracy map further reinforces this is an ongoing global issue, prompting readers to research more about it.

AI Declaration: I have used generative AI within canva to generate some of the icons for this poster. Afterwards, I layered the panels with more icons obtained from canva and added dialogs to each panel. The ideation, planning and organisation of the panels were done independently without the use of generative AI. Some of the prompts used are as follows, "Generate an icon of a cute witch, pirate, dracula and ghost around a campfire having a discussion. The witch should have her finger pointed up. They should all be seated on a log. Generate an icon of this same pirate standing up with a sword in his hand. Generate an icon of a witch standing in four different angles. If needed, I can provide the link to my canva page which I used to layer and create the poster. Thank you!